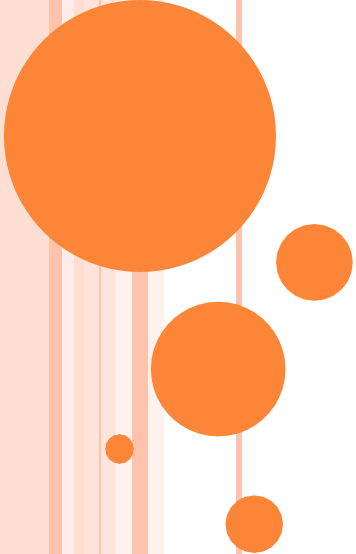




HS-401: Professional Values and Ethics

LECTURE NO 4: *Normative Ethics*

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1.1 Objectives

- Describe normative judgments, and distinguish them from descriptive judgments;
- Describe values, norms, and virtues;
- Describe relativism and absolutism;
- Describe ethical theories, Virtues for morally responsible engineers, care ethics, care ethics in engineering;
- Describe Applied ethics.

1.2 Ethics and Morality(1/2)

- Defining the term ethics is not easy. Ethics has had many meanings over the centuries. The term is derived from the Greek word *ethos*, which can be translated as “custom” or “morals,” but also as “conviction.” “Ethica” stood for the science that considered what was good or bad, wise or unwise, about people’s deeds.
- Over the centuries “moral” has taken on the meaning of the totality of accepted rules of behavior (of a group or culture).
- **Ethics**- *the systematic reflection on what is moral.*
 - Systematic reflection on morality increases our ability to cope with moral problems, and thus moral problems that are related to technology as well.
- **Morality**- *is the whole of opinions, decisions, and actions with which people, individually or collectively, express what they think is good or right.*

1.2 Ethics and Morality(2/2)

- Ethics is a process of searching for the good/right kind of morality. The study of ethics can be both of a descriptive or prescriptive (Normative) nature.
 - *Descriptive Ethics*- The branch of ethics that describes existing morality, including customs, habits, opinions about good and evil, responsible and irresponsible behavior, and acceptable and unacceptable action.
 - *Normative Ethics*- The branch of ethics that judges morality and tries to formulate normative recommendations about how to act or live.

1.3 Descriptive and Normative Judgments

- **Descriptive Judgment-** A judgment that describes what is actually the case(the present), what was the case(the past), or what will be the case(the future).
 - *Descriptive judgments are true or false.*
- **Normative Judgment-** A normative judgment is a value judgment. Value judgments indicate whether some-thing is good or bad, desirable or undesirable; they often refer to how the world should be instead of how it is.

1.4 Values, Norms, and Virtues (1/3)

- **Values-** Lasting convictions or matters that people feel should be strived for in general and not just for themselves to be able to lead a good life or to realize a just society.
- A typical example of this is the slogan of the French Revolution: “liberté, égalité, fraternité” (freedom, equality and brotherhood). This slogan did not express a personal preference – such as “I want to be rich” – but expressed values that were felt to be of importance for everyone.
- A distinction can be made between intrinsic and instrumental values.
 - **Intrinsic Value-** Intrinsic value is an objective in and of itself.
 - **Instrumental Value-** one thing that is valuable in as far as it is a means to, or contributes to something else that is intrinsically good or valuable.
- The value of money for Mr. John Baldwin is intrinsic. He values money independently of what you can do with money. For Mother Theresa, however, money was an instrumental value to realize a higher end: helping the poor.

1.4 Values, Norms, and Virtues (2/3)

- **Norms**- Rules that prescribe what actions are required, permitted, or forbidden.
- Values are often translated into norms/rules, so that it is clear in everyday life how we should act(using rules) to achieve certain values. One example of a value within our traffic system is safety. However, the value(safety) alone is not enough to guarantee safety on the road. To this purpose, we need rules of behavior or norms: prescribed actions that indicate what we must do or must not do in a given situation. The value “safety” in a traffic system is mainly specified by the legal norms/rules from the traffic regulations.

1.4 Values, Norms, and Virtues (3/3)

- **Virtues**- A certain type of human characteristics or qualities.
- The philosopher Alasdair Macintyre describes virtues as a certain type of human characteristics or qualities that has the following five features:
 1. *They are desired characteristics and they express a value that is worth striving for.*
 2. *They are expressed in action.*
 3. *They are lasting and permanent.*
 4. *They are always present, but are only used when necessary.*
 5. *They can be influenced by the individual.*
- The last statement suggests that people can learn virtues. It is a matter of the shaping of a person's character or personality. This occurs during our upbringing or our learning process within an organization. Examples of virtues are justice, honesty, courage, loyalty, creativity, and humor.

1.5 Relativism and Absolutism

- We shall look at two extreme theories that seem to be very tempting at first when it comes to forming a moral judgment:
- **Relativism**- An ethical theory that argues that all moral points of view — all values, norms, and virtues — are equally valid.
 - What is good for one person is not necessarily so for another. A moral judgment is simply a personal opinion.
- **Absolutism**- A rigid form of **universalism** in which no exceptions to rules are possible.
 - **Universalism**- An ethical theory that states that there is a system of norms and values that is universally applicable to everyone, independent of time, place, or culture.
 - In absolutism a norm like “Thou shalt not kill”(You shall not kill) would be considered to be universally applicable, but one can imagine situations where killing a person may be the most morally responsible thing to do. Absolutism does not make any exceptions: a rule is a rule.

1.6 Ethical Theories (1 / 5)

1. Utilitarianism
2. Duty Ethics
3. Right Ethics
4. Virtue Ethics

1.6 Ethical Theories (2/5)

1. *UTILITARIANISM*

- It holds that those actions are good that serve to maximize human well-being. Emphasis in utilitarianism is not on maximizing the well-being of the individual but rather on maximizing the well-being of society as a whole and as such it is somewhat a collectivist approach. E.g. Dam construction
- Two Parts:
 - *Act utilitarianism*: focuses on individual **actions** rather than rules.
 - *Rule utilitarianism*: differs from act utilitarianism, moral **rules** are most important.

1.6 Ethical Theories (3/5)

2. *DUTY ETHICS*

- It comes with terms that there are duties that should be performed regardless of whether these act badly to the most good.
- Duty Ethic and Right ethics are similar to each other.
- *Immanuel Kant* says moral duties are fundamental ethical actions which can be written down as duties. Be honest, don't cause suffering for others, be fair to others.

1.6 Ethical Theories (4/5)

3. *RIGHTS ETHICS*

- They emphasize that we all have moral rights, and any action that violate these rights is ethically unacceptable.
- Right ethics was formulated by John Locke statement: humans have the right to life, liberty and property.

1.6 Ethical Theories (5/5)

4. *VIRTUE ETHICS*

- Virtue is defined as moral distinction and goodness. A virtuous person exhibits good and beneficial qualities.
- Actions are considered right if they support good character traits and wrong if they support bad character traits.
- Focuses on words such as responsibility, honesty, competence, loyalty, trustworthiness, fairness, caring, respect, citizenship.

1.7 Virtues for Morally Responsible Engineers

- Virtues as reliability, honesty, responsibility and solidarity, are quite general and most are virtues that morally responsible engineers need to possess too. If we look more specifically at the virtues engineers need, then we must focus on engineering practice. Michael Pritchard (a mechanical engineer) lists a number of virtues that are more specific that are required for morally responsible engineers.

Virtues for Morally Responsible Engineers

- expertise/professionalism;
- clear and informative communication;
- cooperation;
- willingness to make compromises;
- objectivity;
- being open to criticism;
- stamina;
- creativity;
- striving for quality;
- having an eye for detail; and
- being in the habit of reporting on your work carefully. (Pritchard, 2001)

1.8 Care Ethics

- Care ethics, often referred to as the ethics of care, is a moral and ethical framework that emphasizes the significance of caring relationships and the moral responsibility individuals have in caring for others.
- In care ethics the connectedness of people is key; the mutual responsibility and care for each other. People are connected to each other and through this connection there is attention for your fellow human being. People feel responsible for each other. Care arises from this involvement. Care encompasses all typically human activities that we carry out to maintain, continue, and repair our world, so that we can live in it as best as we can.

1.9 Care Ethics in Engineering

- Although the attempt to develop a care ethics approach to engineering ethics is still in its infancy, care ethics' emphasis on care (e.g., for safety and sustainability) responsibility, and other concerns shared by engineers, suggests that it has a contribution to make to engineering practice. One of the possible applications is a *social ethics of engineering*.
 - Most of the approaches to ethics in engineering focus on the individual. Such approaches tend to neglect the relationships with others in which engineers enter in their work and that are morally relevant. Relevant social arrangements include for example the way a design team or the engineering company is organized and the way that relations with stakeholders are structured.

1.10 Applied Ethics

- Applies normative ethical theories to specific controversial issues.
- Applying theories from philosophers to ethics in everyday life.
- Medical ethics, engineering ethics, legal ethics, political ethics, environmental ethics.

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